

9.1 School catchment walk

To explore how water moves through our school grounds, identify potential pollution sources, and understand how everyday school environments are part of a wider catchment that leads to local creeks, rivers, wetlands or the bay.

Move around the school in small groups with your fieldwork table. Stop at **4 different locations** (e.g., oval corner, carpark, garden bed, drain, walkway). At each location, observe the environment closely and fill in the table to understand how pollutants may end up in local water sources if it rains. Make a simple sketch or label features that help you understand the flow of water.

Location (e.g., oval, carpark, garden bed, drain)	Evidence of Runoff? (Where would water flow when it rains?)	Potential Pollutants Present (check any)	Visible Impacts on the Catchment (What might happen downstream?)	Waterway Health Indicators (even if no creek, infer likely effects)	Notes / Sketch <i>Either</i> draw the area or make brief notes; include the slope direction and any uncertainties.
	- Slope downhill - Gutter - Drain / Grate - Puddle / pooling area - Hard surface (e.g., asphalt, concrete)	- Litter (wrappers, paper, cans) - Leaves / organic debris - Soil / sediment (bare ground, erosion patches) - Fertiliser (lawns, garden beds) - Chemicals (e.g. cleaning products) - Animal poo - Plastics	- Erosion (bare soil, undercut areas) - Clogged drain / blocked gutter - Dirty water flowing into stormwater - Algal bloom risk (nutrient-heavy areas like gardens/fertilisers) - Flooding risk (poor drainage)	- Likely clean runoff - Likely polluted runoff - High sediment load - High nutrient load - Litter likely to enter drains - Possible chemical contamination	
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Reflection Questions

1. Which areas of the school created the cleanest possible runoff? Why?
2. Which areas created the dirtiest or most polluted runoff? Why?
3. Choose one issue you observed (e.g., erosion, rubbish near a drain). What impacts might this have on the catchment and waterways?
4. What is one improvement the school could make to protect its catchment?